ideas about the popularity of the Barakzais. ‘The Europeans who have lately travelled in Afghanistan have generally formed an idea that the Afghans are indifferent if not opposed to the restoration of their ancient King,’ he observed. ‘It ought to be borne in mind that these travellers have in every case been the guests and intimates of that very reigning family [the Barakzais] who would have an interest in impressing them with an opinion favourable to their own reputation.’[85]

By mid-May, Shuja had crossed the Indus and entered Shikarpur without opposition. He then taxed the town’s bankers, filled his coffers with their coin and began drilling his troops. Six months later, on 9 January 1834, Campbell’s troops saw off an attack by a force of Baluchi tribesmen sent by the Amirs of Sindh to arrest Shuja. ‘A party of Baluch danced with their swords as they came into the fight,’ recorded Mirza ‘Ata, who was an eyewitness.

> They harvested with their blades many heads of the royal army, shouting their war-cries till they too were killed. Bravo for their bravery – but alas for their total ignorance of tactics! They dismounted from their horses in the midst of battle and charged on foot uphill, brandishing their swords and yelling like demons, only to be mown down by enemy gunfire before reaching the top. Thus died many Baluch great and small; and the harvest of their lives was scattered to the winds of non-existence . . .
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> On hearing of their defeat, Shuja gave the order that no one should be allowed to cross the river, and that all boats were to be seized. Thus trapped between fire and water the Baluch panicked – and those not daring to return to face their commander preferred to throw themselves in to the river: many were the sights of drowning Baluch begging the ferrymen and sailors to save them, and others holding onto horses’ tails until both horse and man were swept away.[86]

For Shuja, success now bred success. A month later, when he finally set off northwards, his army had grown to 30,000 men and the Shah was in good spirits. ‘Thinking about the huge numbers of my army,’ he explained in his memoirs, ‘it occurred to me to ask what ruler has ever had such a sea of men under his banners, and if so how will anyone be able to stand up to him?’[87] To the Amirs of Sindh who were still trying to raise a new army to oppose him, he sent a challenge which reflected his bullish confidence. ‘Execrable dogs!’ he wrote. ‘God willing, I will give you such a lesson that you shall be an example to the whole world. The only way to treat a rabid dog is to put a rope around his neck. If you are coming to attack us, by all means come. I do not fear you. God is the disposer of events. The country shall belong to the conqueror.’[88]